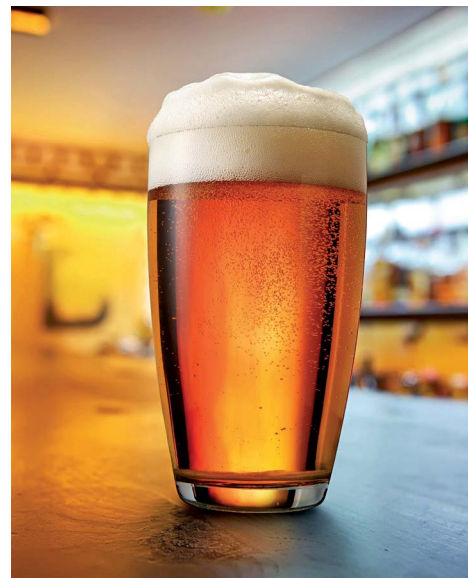




Familiar, friendly, and endlessly tweakable, beer is a crowd-pleaser with room for every palate—from crisp and clean to dark and dessert-like. Some of the most popular varieties include lagers which ferment cold and clean—one reason they dominate India's mass market

tail culture with broadening palates. Last year, he tried a *pani puri* sour that tasted like street food in a glass. He produces a *jowar* lager with millet in the grist for a lower-gluten profile, an oatmeal stout with about 15% oats for body, and an American-style wheat beer flavoured with Nagpur oranges he calls Orange Popsicle. “We use at least one Indian ingredient in each beer and try to debut something new every few months,” says Gandhi. Production has grown to about 5,000 litres a month from 3,000 at launch.

While brewpubs in Delhi are not allowed to bottle their beers, a host of craft beer players across the country are experimenting with flavourful, mild beer. Take Kati Patang, set up by husband-wife duo, Shantanu and Lata Upadhyay, in 2018. The couple quit their corporate careers in consulting and advertising, respectively, to devote their energies to



beer. Their line-up includes Saffron Lager alongside mild styles like Zesty Amber and Snappy Wheat and strong labels such as Bareilly Bold and Bareilly Extra Bold. The wheat beer folds in peppercorn, coriander, ginger, and turmeric, while the lager has saffron. “Our beer is created for the Indian palate,” says Shantanu.

He argues that demand for mild beer is rising because people want the social time more than the punch, though retail remains tilted toward strong as store owners stock what moves the fastest. Regulations complicate the picture. With alcohol laws differing from state to state, smaller players find it difficult to operate across the country. Kati Patang currently sells in Delhi, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand, with Haryana, Chhattisgarh, and Rajasthan next on the company's radar. But it also exports its Saffron Lager to the US.

While you probably don't need an excuse to have beer, if you are looking for one, remember that beer has been brewed for over 5,000 years, and the ancient monks knew what they were doing! **BT**

@smitabw